frameworks and democratic governance. Our main case is Rio de Janeiro. The chapter will finish with the counter-reactions that are growing in host cities against these developments.

Our argument is that the mega-sports events are increasingly aligned with large private interests, strengthen neoliberal city management practices in terms of 'urban entrepreneurship', and suppress the demands and rights of ordinary citizens. In this way, host cities such as Rio become 'cities of exception'. The question the chapter tries to answer is: how do popular forces react to these developments, and why? Will the mass protests that took Brazil and the world by surprise during the 'rehearsal' FIFA World Cup in June 2013 set new standards and bring new types of 'exceptions' to host cities?

Mega-sports events and the 'global city'

In today's globalised world, there is growing interurban competition for international flows of capital and visitors. In order to produce an image of a city that can compete for these resources on the international market, publicity strategies of 'branding' the urban space gain importance (Mascarenhas 2012). Hosting international mega-sports events has recently been adopted as a 'branding' strategy by cities in the Global South. Mega-events like the FIFA World Cup and the Olympics bring with them international capital, tourists and investors, and place the host city in the world's spotlight. The host cities are using the arena of the mega-events to mark themselves as up-and-coming 'global cities' to be reckoned with.

Brazil and Rio de Janeiro's successful bids for the 2007 Pan-American Games, the 2014 FIFA World Cup, and the 2016 Olympics crown the country's remarkable rise after decades of underachievement to becoming an economic and diplomatic heavyweight. Just as the Beijing Olympics of 2008 marked China's revival as a world power (Broudehoux 2007), the 2016 Rio games may be seen as a stamp of approval on the South American giant's coming of age.

Rio de Janeiro's successful bids for these events have been attributed to a fundamental shift in the municipal leadership's strategy during the 1990s. Local scholars point at the rule of the populist-turned-neoliberal mayor, Cesar Maia, as the turning point (Vainer 2000). In 1993, Maia invited the Rio de Janeiro Trading Association (ACRJ) and the Federation of Industries of the State of Rio de Janeiro (FIRJAN) to join the municipality in elaborating a Strategic Plan for the city. A key urban planner from Barcelona, Dr Jordi Borja, was the main consultant. Inspired by the 1992 Barcelona Olympic Games, the plan emphasised the big potential of large projects and mega-events, such as the Olympic Games,